

JUST YOUR REGULAR LAPTOP

Here, we take a look at what's available in the sub-50,000 price band, which can also be used as PC replacements.

As expected, the category was choc-a-block with laptops from ACi, Zenith, Acer, Gigabyte, and Compaq. In all, 12 models made it to this category, offering affordable mobility.

Look And Feel

Laptops still exude a feeling of luxury, so look and feel matter. The Compaq V6102AU is undoubtedly the best-looking laptop of the bunch. Its black body with its lustrous finish is outstanding, and the design refreshingly new. Acer notebooks come second-best in terms of finish and build quality. The design is typical Acer—subtle silver-grey on the lid and matte black on the inside—nothing's wrong with this, but we'd appreciate a cosmetic makeover. None of the ACi models could match the Compaq or Acer's. Gigabyte and Zenith seem to have a monolithic approach as far as designing laptops goes. The silver-black combination is just too drab and dated. Build quality, however, wasn't an issue here; they felt sturdy.

Ergonomics

Cutting corners to lower prices is the most preferred way of going about releasing any entry-level product. With laptops, the keyboard, touchpad and hinges are where such compromises often happen. When buying a laptop, get a good feel of the keyboard and the touchpad—they speak volumes for the overall quality.

The Compaq Presario V6102AU again comes out tops on ergonomics—the keyboard offers good resistance and feel, and the touchpad is equally good. However, the buttons are a bit mushy. The Acer twins come close to perfection—the keyboards are really good, but the touchpads are a tad glossy. Strangely enough, the lower-specification TravelMate 2428 comes with a nice curved keyboard, while the higher-priced Aspire 5551 comes with a regular keyboard.

The Zenith, Gigabyte, and ACi laptops have fair ergonomics, but there's nothing special. The keyboard on the ACi Emerald C2 is a tad better than those on the rest, though.

Specifications

As one would expect, the models in this category are fitted with low-end processors such as the Celeron M, but the Pentium M, Core Duo, and AMD Turion are also found happily crunching numbers in these entry-level laptops. Both the Intel 915GM and 945GM were used extensively, while Compaq's stunning V6102AU was based on NVIDIA's GeForce 6150 platform, with Zenith's Executive model being based on VIA's P4M800 Pro.

The i915GM is slightly older than the i945GM, and that's evident from the memory scores. What's interesting is that the NVIDIA platform delivers performance equivalent to that of the Intel platform in most tests.

The Compaq V6102AU was the only laptop in the entry-level category to come with a full gigabyte of memory—which was, no doubt reflected in the scores. The Gigabyte W431UD, ACi Icon S, and ACi Ethos Duo sported 512 MB of memory, and the rest dragged along with a paltry 256 MB, and sharing it with the graphics controller to boot! We suggest you bump up the memory to at least 512 MB when using Windows XP.

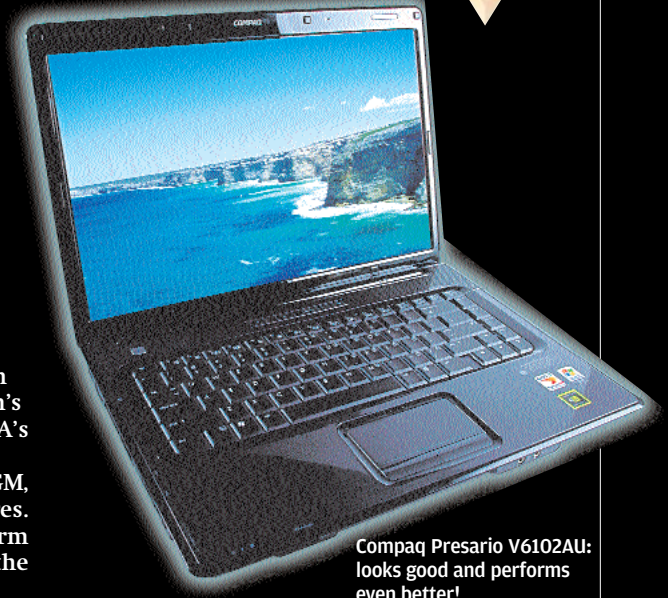
Coming to storage, Compaq's V6102AU had a 100 GB hard drive crammed in, followed by ACi (80 GB). Gigabyte and Zenith gave out 40 and 60 GB drives respectively. On the storage front, the more the merrier, but you should choose according to your usage.

14-inch widescreens were the norm, except the Compaq V6102AU and Zenith Strategist, which provided 15.4-inch screens. If you want real estate, opt for the 15.4 inch widescreen models—the extra screen area helps when working with applications such as Excel and Photoshop.

Frills at best included memory card readers, Gigabit LAN on certain models such as the Zenith Strategist and the ACi Ethos Duo 1530, and switches for Wi-Fi. Compaq has included a little button on the top of the touchpad to deactivate—comes in real handy during lots of keyboard usage. Finally, the Zenith Strategist and Presario V6102AU were the only laptops in this category that allow watching movies without starting the OS.

Performance

With AMD's Turion at 1.6 GHz, 1 GB of memory and NVIDIA's 6150 chipset at its disposal, the Compaq V6102AU was undoubtedly the best performer. It scored equally well across the barrage of tests we threw at it. Whether it was pure processing power or a memory-intensive test, the Compaq was up there with the best Intel-based notebooks. However, it seems battery life isn't the platform's best strength—this



Compaq Presario V6102AU: looks good and performs even better!